

cover story PRATIBHA PATIL

THE WINNER TAKES IT ALL

PRATIBHA PATIL'S WIN IS A MORALE-BOOSTER FOR THE CONGRESS. AFTER LOSING THE CONSCIENCE VOTE AND WITH THE NEXT GENERAL ELECTIONS NOT TOO FAR AWAY, BJP IS DOUBLY DISTRESSED.



■ By Priya Sahgal

The country has finally got its first woman President. The three lakh-plus margin is merely the icing on a cake that was baked and served by another woman president, Congress supremo Sonia Gandhi. On the eve of the presidential polls, while hosting a dinner for the UPA, Sonia was told that Farooq Abdullah, a fence sitter, had decided to support her nominee. Delighted, she told her guests, "The National Conference has been added to the menu!"

The Congress has reason to celebrate Pratibha Patil as its lucky charm. Not only did her swearing-in coincide with a smoothening of the nuclear deal with the US, but more than that, her win was a morale-booster for the party. It proved that despite losing almost every Assembly election since it came to power at the Centre, it could still sway some numbers within and outside the UPA alliance. To BJP, the message was equally clear and much less cheerful. Let alone NDA, even some of its own MLAs did not vote for the party candidate. With as many as six northern states slated to go to polls within the next 18 months and the general elections due in 2009, this was a very worrying sign of the times. More so when

most of the BJP MLAs who cross-voted belonged to two of the states poised for Assembly elections—Madhya Pradesh and Gujarat.

With the electoral college tipped in UPA's favour, the presidential election was a foregone conclusion. BJP tried to turn this war of numbers into a moral battle, pitching a statesman against a candidate with questionable credentials. This was a battle for the conscience vote. Perhaps the party overplayed its hand. Perhaps the Congress was better at managing allies. Even anti-Congress fence sitters like Trinamool Congress, Samajwadi Party and Telugu Desam Party preferred to waste their ballot than vote for Bhairon Singh Shekhawat. In the end, there was only a huge political defeat for the party, and no moral victory.

Damage control within BJP has been swift. Party MLAs who had cross-voted against Shekhawat have been suspended. Even before the new President